Like Vengu Aiyar and Sadhu Ganapati Panthulu, K. Balaji Rao, one of the persecuted vakils, went to Coimbatore in May 1908 to sell shares. As *The Hindu*'s Coimbatore correspondent rued, few had taken up shares in Coimbatore 'to the great discredit' of the district, and expressed the hope that now that Balaji Rao was striving so hard, 'poor and dull' as the city was, it could still make amends.[87] Two weeks later, a more realistic correspondent, struck a sorry note saying that only 200 shares had been taken in Coimbatore: 'there are people who are willing to pay but poor. There are others who are able to pay but unwilling to do so. All of us talk, all of us pronounce sympathy but as for action, it is a big zero.'[88]

A police report gives another side to *The Hindu*'s Coimbatore story. When Balaji Rao was at Pollachi, he happened to stay in the same lodging as a tahsildar. When he was away, two sub-inspectors came to see the tahsildar. Informed of this, Balaji Rao, the CID reported with satisfaction, 'bolted to Tuticorin leaving his baggage behind, apparently fearing arrest!' Though he returned two weeks later, after confirming that his fear was unwarranted, the momentum had been lost and the promised 300 shares to be subscribed by local pleaders did not materialize. Later Balaji Rao did manage to sell ten shares to four persons: the police report records their names—the government was keen on tracking anyone who contributed to the company.[89] That even a lawyer who had so boldly faced the security proceedings initiated by a vindictive Ashe and had stood witness to VOC could be so intimidated speaks for the mood of fear.[90] (Balaji Rao's fund-raising tour of Coimbatore was punctuated by at least two visits to Tirunelveli to stand witness in the sedition case.)

If the Swadeshi lawyers strained every nerve, K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar went a step further. We may recall that, despite being K.R. Guruswami Aiyar's brother, he was VOC's ally and played a creditable role in the Coral Mills strike, contributing significantly from his own pocket, not to speak of his help in organizing relief work. Such was his commitment, that by July, he had given up his practice to devote himself more fully to the Swadeshi company.[91] From the timing, it appears that he made this decision following